

99 Huldah

The prophetess the king's men consulted when the Book of the Law was found.

Huldah lived in Jerusalem in the days of King Josiah. She was married to Shallum, the keeper of the royal wardrobe, and Scripture calls her "the prophetess." In 622 BC, workers repairing the temple found the Book of the Law. When it was read to Josiah, he tore his clothes in grief and sent his highest officials to ask the LORD what it meant. They went to Huldah. Her answer was clear and brave. Judgment would come on Jerusalem, just as the Book said. But because the king's heart was tender, the disaster would not come in his lifetime. Her words moved Josiah to lead the nation in renewing its covenant with God.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Chuldah</i> , often explained as "weasel" or "mole"
Family	Wife of Shallum son of Tikvah, keeper of the wardrobe (2 Kings 22:14)
Home	Jerusalem, in "the college," probably a newer district
When	Josiah's eighteenth year, c. 622 BC
Key people	Josiah, Hilkiah the priest, Shaphan the scribe, Ahikam, Achbor, Asahiah
Main passages	2 Kings 22:8–20; 2 Chronicles 34:14–28
New Testament	Not named

"Because thine heart was tender, and thou hast humbled thyself before the LORD ... and hast rent thy clothes, and wept before me; I also have heard thee, saith the LORD."

2 Kings 22:19, KJV

The life of Huldah

Dates are approximate (BC) and agree with the Josiah chapter. All we know of Huldah comes from one scene, told twice.

- Before c. 622 BC

In Jerusalem

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A prophetess at home

Huldah lives in Jerusalem's second quarter with her husband Shallum, who keeps the wardrobe, probably the royal or temple robes. *2 Kings 22:14; 2 Chronicles 34:22*
- c. 622 BC

Josiah's 18th year

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The Book is found

Hilkiah the high priest finds the Book of the Law in the temple. Shaphan reads it to the king, who tears his clothes. *2 Kings 22:8-13*
- c. 622 BC

The same year

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The king's men come

Josiah sends Hilkiah, Shaphan, Ahikam, Achbor and Asahiah to inquire of the LORD. They go to Huldah. *2 Kings 22:12-14; 2 Chronicles 34:20-22*
- c. 622 BC

Her answer

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Judgment and mercy

She says the Book's curses will fall on Jerusalem, because the people have forsaken God. But Josiah will be gathered to his grave in peace. *2 Kings 22:15-20; 2 Chronicles 34:23-28*
- c. 622 BC

Soon after

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The covenant renewed

The king gathers the people, reads the Book to them, and makes a covenant to follow the LORD. *2 Kings 23:1-3*
- c. 609 and 586 BC

Years later

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Her words come true

Josiah dies before the disaster, and Jerusalem falls to Babylon about 36 years after her prophecy. *2 Kings 23:29-30; 25:8-10*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Huldah.

Old Testament

2 Kings 22:14–20	and 2 Chronicles 34:22–28. The two accounts of her prophecy.
2 Kings 23:1–3	The covenant renewal that followed.
Echoes	Miriam and Deborah were earlier prophetesses (Exodus 15:20; Judges 4:4). Isaiah's wife is called "the prophetess" (Isaiah 8:3). God promised to pour out his Spirit so that "your sons and your daughters shall prophesy" (Joel 2:28).

New Testament

Echoes	Anna the prophetess speaks of the child Jesus in the temple (Luke 2:36–38). Peter quotes Joel's promise at Pentecost (Acts 2:16–18). Philip the evangelist had four daughters who prophesied (Acts 21:9).
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For discussion

1. *Observe:* What were the two parts of Huldah's message (2 Kings 22:15–20)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think Josiah's officials trusted Huldah to tell them the truth?
3. *Apply:* Huldah gave an unwelcome message faithfully. When have you needed to say something true but hard? How did you do it?
4. *Apply:* Josiah's tender heart mattered to God. What would it look like for you to respond to Scripture with that kind of heart this week?